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Hank Cicalo

Hank Cicalo's career as a recording engineer has spanned over fifty years. His expertise contributed to the success of artists including Carole King, George Harrison, Tom Scott, Cannonball Adderley and the Monkees. Hank was a first-call engineer for major labels such as Dot Records, A&M, and RCA.

Hank was interviewed via Zoom on April 20, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased to have Hank Cicalo with me today. And I'm going to start out with a statement and see if you agree with it, Hank, and that is for 60-some years you've had one of the coolest jobs possible.

HC: Very true.

MR: Because I've been reading about you and I say oh, I wanted to be in the booth for that and you could just think of so many moments. I'd like to put — imagine you at age oh somewhere between age 13 and 14 and I was looking at the pop songs, the top popular songs of those years. And I see things like Doris Day "Sentimental Journey" and Perry Como "Prisoner of Love." And if we kept going we'd arrive at "Rock Around the Clock" and Elvis Presley. So my question, what was it in popular music being played on the radio do you recall anything in particular that really made an impression on you?

HC: Oh are you talking about records that I've heard that I wanted to —

MR: Yes.

HC: Oh gosh there were so many in those days. I've a name blockage but there were so many albums, albums that I did, "Tapestry," "Rhymes and Reasons." In all those days I really loved the big bands, I mean I really loved doing a lot of those. I recorded so many great artists over my career: Shorty Rodgers, Peggy Lee, the Lennon Sisters, I mean I worked for A&M Records for several years. I worked for Lou Adler, Merry Clayton, Gene McDaniels albums, "The Rocky Horror Show," stuff like that.

MR: What was it that sent you into this career? Was there some kind of moment?

HC: Oh no, not at all. I'd served four years in the Marine Corps. I got out of the Marine Corps and I started taking an electronic course, an engineering course at Columbia University. I got a job as a pick-up job, I'd come in and pick up some slack in some small studio and that led me into that. Before long I had quit working in school and got a job in the studio, and that was the end of that. I've worked in a studio in New York. I didn't like the cold weather after spending a couple of years in Korea. I wanted to move to California. And there was no job offers at all. Anyway I came to California and worked in some small studios and I finally got a job at A&M.

MR: Was it rather like an apprenticeship? Then you learned your craft by sitting next to somebody else?

HC: Yeah, no, no. There's no — at that time — there's now schools and stuff for engineering but at that time there was no school for engineering. I just happened to get a lucky job working at a small studio in New York. And that led me into some bigger jobs and then I decided to come to California. I didn't have a job but I just had to get out of New York, it was getting too cold. After being in Korea for a couple of years I wanted to get to the sun. So I left and I worked at Armed Forces Radio when I came out. It was the only job I could get in California. And luckily I got a job at RCA and started my career at RCA. It was great. I was at RCA for about ten years. It was a good learning experience, it was wonderful. I made contact with a lot of great artists: Tom Scott and I got into Ode Records, and I worked for Lou Adler, which was great. Lou was a wonderful, wonderful producer along with so many others. But anyway I've worked with Lou and we did "Rhymes and Reasons," "Fantasy," and stuff with Carole King.

MR: Do you feel that you had to have sort of — I'm not sure how to put this — like a different set of ears for when you had like the Lennon Sisters come in and then you had Peggy Lee, and then you had Cannonball, then you had a rock group.

HC: No. You know as a studio engineer I worked at Capitol and I worked at RCA Victor before I really became an independent engineer. But that was a great training ground because I got to work with so many different artists. And you know it was a great training ground. And I worked with people like Don Costa for the first time and you know it was great. I went to work for Ode Records and I worked with Lou Adler a lot and I worked for A&M Records but Lou had an affiliation and had started Ode Records and whatever. And I worked with Lou, which was a great experience. Great producer. His style was so much different from the producers I'd been working with. You know at Capitol and RCA you work with producers that came in with a score and they made it really strict and the artist had to stay with it. Then I started working with those independent guys like Lou Adler. It was a whole different kind of thing, it wasn't like a really strict bang-up thing. When you worked with Lou everything was loose and you were working for the artists, everything had to be comfortable for the artist and so I got into that whole thing with them too. I mean we worked with the control room lights down and I always tried to make it so that the artists were in the room and you're in another room. I would always try to work with the lights down in the control room and it gave it a better feeling because the artists would always look in the control room. If they couldn't see you that well they'd act better because they were concentrating on what they were doing instead of trying to impress the producer. You know?

MR: Yeah I can see that. They're looking through the glass and they can be affected either way like if they see somebody on the other side of the glass shaking their head thinking uh oh, I'm not doing this right. In fact they could just be shaking their head about anything.

HC: The thing that worked better was, having worked with Lou Adler and I worked with Lou a lot, and he was such a great producer. You know he did the Mamas & Papas and all that stuff. I started working with Lou and Carole King and my thing has always been to make sure that the artists were comfortable. I know there are a lot of engineers that get into arguments about earphones, before they even started a date. And stuff like that. My thing was always to try to make it as comfortable as possible. I would keep the lights in the control room down. They didn't need to see us. You know? We needed to see them. And it helped because then the artists were not tied down into looking into the booth to see what the producer was doing and what the engineers were doing. If I kept the lights down and the lights in the studio up and I tried to make it as comfortable as possible, I would set up dates where if it was a rhythm section and an artist singing I would try to wrap the band around the artist. Even if the artist was in a booth I always tried to set it up so that everybody could see each other and then it was much more of a feeling. A lot of engineers would put the drums in a drum booth, the guitar into this booth. I never felt that really worked. Putting the artist maybe in a vocal booth was okay because you might want to do the vocals over again or the artist felt it was more comfortable, and sometimes we just did it and it worked fine. But some artists, they wanted to come back in again and do the vocals. So you had to work with that situation, make them comfortable was always the object of the whole thing. I saw dates the guys would set up and they'd put the artist right in the middle of the room facing the control room and everybody's looking at the artist and they're getting a little bit uncomfortable. I always tried to make it really comfortable for an artist and it was a thing that a lot of guys didn't think about. For me, I would set up a vocal booth and I'd make sure there was water there, I'd make sure there were clean cups, I made sure if there was a chair or stool that the artist was sitting on was comfortable. I tried to make it as comfortable as possible out in the room. I remember, I saw guys with artists, even if they were overdubbing they'd put them in a booth with a microphone in there and then like they felt they were locked in. Some people just worked fine, other people felt really constricted by working that way.

MR: Did you work with producers that tended to over-hype the artist, like give them pep talks: "You're going to be great, this is going to be terrific"?

HC: A few. Most of the producers I ever worked with, Tom Mack, at Capitol, and at RCA, those guys would let you set it up. And as long as the artist was comfortable, and that's the way I always felt — I put the rug down, put a couple of flats behind them, if they

wanted the room a little darker, if they didn't want to face the control room, I always tried to work with them. If you get the artist comfortable and relaxed it's 90 percent of the battle, you know? I hated to take more time, I'd start a date and then they'd tell the — make the changes, do this, do that, do that. And it would always interfere with what the vocalist was doing or the performer was doing. My thing was always to make them comfortable. Sometimes I would go out and ask them and then say, especially to the chicks a lot of times, "I don't want to look in the booth." That's okay with me, I'd set it up so that they were looking out of the studio, if they felt more comfortable looking out that way rather than looking at three stone faces in the studio control room: the producer, the engineer, and the guy running the machines, and nobody is smiling and nobody is looking really good, you know, it really turns the artist down a little but. My object was always to make it comfortable for the artist out there. I brought in rugs, a chair, a music stand, maybe a table with water and clean cups and stuff like that. You always try to make the artist that's performing out there, if they're a vocalist especially, to make them feel comfortable. Some artists never liked to look into the control booth. And I don't blame them — with these stony faces looking at them. You know? Some artists like to look out of the room. I always tried to make it as comfortable as you can for the artist to sing.

MR: Could you tell when a producer had also been or was an engineer? And might you butt heads with them if you're making microphone choices for instance and the producer goes, "Oh no, no, I don't think you want that one on the bass drum" or whatever. Did you ever butt heads with people about those kinds of things?

HC: I never really had that much trouble with producers wanting to do something differently. Usually the producer would say you know this particular artist doesn't like to look in the booth. Okay, fine, so you set them up facing the studio. You've got to make the artist as comfortable as possible. And that was — because it made it easier for you. I can remember dates with guys would talk, artists would talk about, "I hated to go to that guy. He always put me in a dark room and I couldn't sing and I couldn't see the music." You've got to make the artist as comfortable as possible. Whether you're working with an artist live in a booth and you've got a 60-piece orchestra out there, you've got to remember that the artist is the artist. They're the ones that are performing. You've got to make sure that they're comfortable, that their earphones are right, that the balance that they're hearing is a record balance. You know? There are guys who will say, "Well the artist needs to hear the piano, and just the piano." That's not right. If the artist can hear the orchestra surrounding them and they're wearing a pair of earphones in a booth I mean you've got to close your eyes and think you're someplace else. I've always asked the artist, "How do you feel about that?" Well you know, and you get an answer. "I don't like

to look in the booth when there's people in there. I don't like to see the lights on." I always worked with my lights down low once I got the balance I needed and that was it. People would look at me and say, "Gee are you guys in the booth?" "Yeah." My thing was you get it as comfortable out there. For example with Carole King, Carole liked to work, because she was a musician, she liked to work with the band. So I had to set up those dates with a piano in the middle of the room and Carole would be there, and surround her with the band, be it a couple of guitars, the drummer, I just set them up so — the only way I could describe it is they were sitting in Carole's living room. The more comfortable it is out there, the most comfortable their hearing is, their earphones are right, the balance is right, the room feels — all those things are part of making a good record. You know I've seen guys put everybody in a booth. Two guitars are in one booth and the guys on the other side of the room are in another room, the artist is in another booth. They don't even see each other. That's wrong. If you put an artist in a booth and surround the booth with the players so that the artist in the booth can see those players. Certainly the drums are in the middle of the room but then the bass player and there's a couple of guitar players and a keyboard player, you want to keep them all tight so that they all bounce off of each other. These dates where you get the guy puts the piano in another room, and the booth is in another room and the drums are in another room, you know to me my work was — it never worked because the band could never feel that they're working with a band. I tried to always make the dates so that the guitar players could look at the drummer, the bass player could look at the — everybody had to look at each other.

MR: Can I ask you about "Tapestry" and did you have a feeling with that record in particular that this was going to be a hit?

HC: I'll tell you, having done a lot of albums all those years you get a feeling once in a while about an album, this is going to be good. Generally you say this is good but they never quite make it. "Tapestry" was, right from the go we felt it. And my method of setting up an orchestra or a band — well not an orchestra, that's a different situation — but a rhythm section, a couple of guitars, piano and drums — I tried to make them — surround them, so that they could all see each other. I hated that thing where you put the drums are in a booth and you want them in a booth, that's fine. Then build the rest of the band around the booth so they all can see each other. These dates, they're stiff when you put the drummer in a booth and then you put the two guitar players on the other side of the room somewhere and the bass player he's somewhere else and has no contact with the drummer. Those dates are stiff. They don't work for me. My feeling has always been that they all have eye contact — I'm sorry — with the rhythm section but they all have eye contact with the artist. I would put the artist in the middle of the room with the whole

band sitting around it made, for him, it made them feel more comfortable because they had more contact. You put everybody in the booth — the drummer's over in this booth and the singer's in that booth, and the guys are here — it never felt right to me you know, because those poor guys are all sitting in a room playing and there's no eye contact. They don't see each other.

MR: Who makes the decisions about who to call in for like horn solos? Like Tom Scott spoke very highly about you and he talked about playing on that session. Is that the producer's call or do you have a role in that?

HC: You mean if I'm working with a producer?

MR: Yes. I mean who makes those decisions about —

HC: No the producer has it. I haven't worked with very many guys, producers, who weren't really cool, who weren't really good. Because I guess my reputation, whatever, was one that I would work with the producer. But don't be a smart ass right off the bat and tell me what to do. You know? I mean walk on dates here. "I want the guitar in that room, I want this guy in that room." It never worked for me. I always wanted them — you can isolate them and still have eye contact. Eye contact is so important to a rhythm section because they're just getting the music for the first time. They haven't even seen these things, the music that is. So what you want them to do is to have those rehearsal times, they're really important where they're in the booth, I mean they're in the studio and they're working and before you even start recording you want that to be as comfortable as possible. So I never did things like — I always made sure that the earphones worked because I don't want in the middle of a date to have a guitar player say, "I can't hear myself." That would always stop a date cold. So you always tried to work it out so that everybody was looking at each other, everybody was — if you had a guitar situation where the guitars are too loud you can go out and talk to those guys. You can put up a couple of flats around them. And if you talk to them in the right way and you're not bending down, the fact that artistically you don't want to deal with that, but you as an engineer want to have the ability to be able to control the parts that are around you. That's what you want to do. If they're facing each other fine. If they're in the booth that's fine. As long as they're comfortable. They have to be comfortable and hearing — what they're hearing in those earphones are really important and you always get those situations. Years ago I used to get, "I want more bass, I want more." I want more this, more, more, more. I used to put up signs, "More, More, More."

MR: Yeah no one ever asks for less, right?

HC: Pardon me?

MR: I said no one ever asks for less.

HC: Yeah sure. If you have a good mix in the phones it gives the artist — whoever the artist might be — it might be with a guitar player in the room — you've got to make them all feel comfortable. The earphones are really important. You get that really good balance in the earphones — I would do things like guys would put on the phones immediately and start, "No, no, no." I'd say, "Give me a chance to get a mix and we'll work on the phones after that." And generally that usually worked. Even at the beginning of the date they put the phones on but I'm just still getting a bass sound or I'm getting — you know it's not really right yet you know. I would think, sometimes I'd say, "Don't put on the phones yet, let me get a mix, I've got an earphone mix" I said, if they're comfortable out there and they're all kind of facing each other, the rhythm section especially, facing each other. If you're working with a big band you can't do that. If you have a band you have to have a lead singer or something like that you put them in the booth, that's going to work, that's going to be fine. But remember that artist is the one that's going to dictate what the rest of the thing — I mean I've worked with guys like Vic Damone and — because I can't think of anybody else right now — but you know you've got to make them feel comfortable. And they will tell you I mean I would always ask the artist, "Are you all right? Are you comfortable?" And sometimes you know they'd say, "I want to hear more piano" or I want to hear — you know you've got to make them feel comfortable. Even if that makes us wrong out there in the earphones, at least they're comfortable. If they're comfortable making the record then you're fine.

MR: I told you that I am a huge fan of Cannonball Adderley. I wondered, when you recorded them did Cannonball and Nat have to be in a separate booth?

HC: No.

MR: You just had the band playing?

HC: No. Everybody out there, everybody facing each other, everybody having contact. That was my thing always, to make the artist comfortable. If the artist wanted to sit with the drummer I'd put her out there with the drummer. You know? That's his problem, not mine at that point. You know? I mean you'd get into the things, "I want to sit by the piano player because he can't keep himself in time" or something.

MR: I see. But generally speaking the jazz records, the jazz recordings took less time and I'm wondering, with Cannonball, would they play a tune and finish it and then come into the booth and like check it out, then say okay?

HC: No. Everybody's always checking it out. I mean right? In the studio they might work if you've got a group, and they might work on a tune for 15, 20 minutes. And you get your thing together in 20 minutes. I mean the guys out there, they're not really interested in what you're doing other than the fact that they want their phones to sound right. So really immediately when you're starting a date immediately you've got to make the phones

right. They haven't played two bars yet and they're complaining about the phones. I would say, take the phones off, you know, let me get a balance and then we'll go for it — and then you can ask more bass, more this more that. At least you get an engineer — I've never had trouble with the players. I know engineers have trouble with players. My feeling about rhythm sections was always not to put them all in booths all over the room but to put them together in a room so they're all facing each other. So if it's a guitar that's really loud you can put him in a booth as long as he's hearing it in his phone, and that makes it better for you to control it and it makes them comfortable so that they're not overriding each other. And you could talk to them, I mean you know these guys, you could say, "Hey Jim, turn it down a little bit." Or "Billy, the bass amplifier is too loud either turn it down or turn it away" we'll work it out. You've got to make them comfortable. If the artists are comfortable your job is so much easier.

MR: How about when it comes to mixing? Who did you like to have in the booth when it came time for mixing, or who didn't you want to have in the booth?

HC: I never had too much trouble with that. I mean if you've got a producer you have a producer. If the artist is producing, as long as you give them that first playback where they're comfortable and their ears are comfortable it makes it easier for you. You know that first playback when you do a tune and they're working out there for an hour and a half you get in front of it, you make three or four takes and they come in and listen, you've got to be right on it. You know you've got to figure out before they even set up sometimes who's the lead artist, who's the lead guitar, whatever. You get a good drum sound. Earphones are important. With the right earphone mix, like I would some days say, "Don't put on the phones yet" and I would get as much as I could out of the date and then I would go to the earphones and work really carefully on the earphone and then ask the guys, "Are you comfortable? Your earphones are right?" If the earphones are right and they're hearing a nice mix in their phones, man, your job is a lot easier.

MR: Were you subject to the clock? In other words if a record company had a certain budget for this artist were you feeling like well we've spent four hours today and we've got one tune down, this thing has to speed up? Or was that not your — was that more on the producer to make that call?

HC: That's not my job. If you're working with a producer that's his job. I mean if you run over because he's screwing around with a tune that he doesn't really like anyway you've got a problem. I mean you could take a three hour date and work on one tune. You know? If you're working on an album you could spend a day on one tune or if the producer feels this might be the single or whatever. You want more control over it, you want to deal with it more, you know, it just depends on the act and the producers. Some producers, the older producers, the guys that were really old time, guys that worked at Capitol and RCA

I mean by old producers I mean guys who were musicians to begin with, they were steady guys, they worked for RCA or Columbia or whatever, they were company oriented. They had so much to do in a date and they would try to make — if there were three tunes a date we did three tunes a date. It depends on the artist. I mean you can't stifle, I've seen it happen boy and that's the worst thing in the world, where you get a producer to say, "All right come on let's go. Hurry up." I never felt you ever got them to perform. I worked with Lou Adler, you know, who really produced so many great records, and if things in the studio were not happening quite well and you know they're close, he would let them develop up there. He wouldn't be on the button right away, "Let's do a take now." Lou would make sure that everything out there was comfortable and he made me make sure, you know. "How are the phones, Hank? Make sure the phones are all right." Good producers will do that.

MR: Yeah it's interesting that you said some of the older producers were musicians first. Like they could read the score. If Billy Mays wrote a score or something —

HC: Absolutely.

MR: Yeah, they could see if it was literally being played correctly.

HC: I'll tell you guys would surprise me sometimes. I've worked with Lou Adler a lot because of Tom Scott and Gene McDaniels, Merrick Clayton, you know he had a nice roster of acts and Lou would always make sure that the artists were comfortable. I mean if we got out one tune a day he was happy with that. Then you had the other producers that were working for — like the company kind of guys you know, guys like RCA, stiff as they were, I mean they had to get three tunes a day, blah-blah-blah-blah. Everything had to be rout—. And the problem with that is that if you're going to do it that way then the producer has to sit down and work with that artist before you even get in the booth, unless you've been working with the artist for a long time you want [*** 36:16 inaudible]. But if it's a fairly new artist, the producer has to be there sitting. From experience I've seen, especially big companies — Capitol, RCA — they assign a producer to the particular act. That didn't mean, he didn't even know the guy. I mean you know? They'd go out and have a cup of coffee and that was it.

MR: And artists a lot of times, especially the solo singers, they may be coming in and hearing this orchestration for the first time. They may have sat with a piano player and gone through arrangements but then if you have a whole string section or a big band it must take time for the art sort of to adjust themselves to that.

HC: Unless you have an artist that's never done that, you know like if you have an artist that's worked live and he has a band surrounding him and you know he's working at whatever, a stage show, whatever, he's used to that custom. You put a speaker by him or whatever, to make them comfortable, they want to hear more of the band. But you know it's really

— the object is to make the artist as comfortable as possible. I emphasize that more than anything. Even the simplest things sometimes will distract. My thing is, give me a second, give me a minute, if I'm setting up a vocal and we've already done the tracks, the vocalist is standing in the studio with a pair of earphones on in a bare room, and it's cold. I mean most of those artists, I would ask artists, when I would do a vocal booth I'd get a rug on the floor, I'd put some flats behind the artist, I made sure that the music stands looked right, there was a table next to them so he could put his water, coffee or whatever else. You know put a couple of flats behind them and close the room down a little bit, give them a high chair, you know a rug, make sure that the artist — and I'd put a couple of flats behind him to close the room down, you've got to make the artist comfortable. I don't care if you're working in a toilet you've got to make them feel comfortable. And listen, I've done vocals for an artist in the bathroom because they liked the echo sound in the bathroom. That's pretty out, you know? Put a microphone into the bathroom.

MR: You know I've had engineers tell me that on occasion they would assign a fader that did nothing, and if a producer or an ad person was in there and said can you give me a little more —

HC: No.

MR: No? You didn't have to do that?

HC: Na, na, na. That's bullshit. That's like you're killing the artist, you're killing everybody. That's baloney. You've got to make it work. You can't hide anybody. Now I'm going to do this and then they won't hear it? They're going to hear it of course. You know —

MR: Did it make a difference —

HC: The relationship in the bigger studios — Capitol, RCA, whatever — by the time you got an artist down there in the booth, I mean in the studio, they pretty well know what's going on. They've heard the band, they've been there, done their work vocals. Sometimes you've got an artist that wants to do a finished vocal, they're good enough to do it with the band out in the room, whether it be with a small rhythm session or a big band. The older artist working with a big band, Peggy Lee, whatever ensemble, but they're used to working with a band. Then you get some of these artists that are not used to — they're working with a small trio, now you start to dress them up with a rhythm section and studio players that are playing straight — you know you can't have amateur hour now you know.

MR: Yeah. Did it make a difference — I worked in a studio for a while and the fellow had, the engineer had of course speakers in the walls in the booth but then he had a couple of Auratone like just small speakers.

HC: Yeah.

MR: He would check the mix on those things I guess because he was thinking about car radios or that kind of thing?

HC: Car radios was always the answer. I worked with producers, "Give me a mix, you put it on a cassette, I'm going to play it in my car." That's nuts. Is his car now the epitome of this is what it's going to sound like? No. You're going to make a sound for the best speakers you can. That will always work. If you're going to try to work for a small speaker, you know my car is different than your car you know. You can't do that. You've got to make a good mix, and it's always like a radio mix. What you're trying to do is to sell the record. So you know I never thought — occasionally a guy would say, "I want a car mix" and that's nonsense. And I've also had producers who, "Give me a cassette," he runs out in the parking lot and puts it in his car to listen to what it sounds like. I mean that used to knock me out. "I've got to listen, make a cassette I'm going to go out to my car and listen to it." His car is now the epitome of what a record should sound like.

MR: How about the final product? When we moved from LPs to CDs did it change necessarily the way you recorded things and the final product?

HC: It better not. I mean if you're working with a vocalist let's say and you get a nice mix, you're going to have that mix all the way. You know? You can't suddenly change unless like you do a vocal with a rhythm section and you know they're going to add strings or horns or something like that. Then that's a different ballgame. The artist has to make sure that he just does his vocal. You know he has to disfranchise himself from a band. He's working with a rhythm section. It's kind of different. Some work very well that way. There were some acts that just sang better, felt better doing live vocals with a band. You know? Very few though, I must say.

MR: Who did you like to see especially coming on a date as far as the rhythm section players? Did you have favorite drummers?

HC: Oh, oh yea. You have favorite drummers, you have favorite bass players. And strangely — well not strangely enough — I mean the guys that work together, for example like in New York I always — the New York players, I loved the way New York players play, what Steve Gadd played with Richard Tee, and always those New York guys had a different feel. Because they worked together so often and they knew how each — you know. In L.A. it was different because you'd have — like in New York what I'm talking about was it was an A band. The A band was Richard Tee, I'm trying — but they had a rhythm section that was their rhythm section and it worked for almost everybody. They wanted the best guys.

MR: Like those guys in Stuff.

HC: It was always Ralph McDonald on percussion and you know the same guitar players.

MR: Bucky Pizzarelli?

HC: Yeah.

MR: But in L.A. that was different then.

HC: Well the New York, since in New York there was a clique of guys, maybe ten guys. They worked all the time. Be it two bass players or two drummers or whatever. In other words they were like the on-call guys. They worked all the time. And then there were a lot of other guys that worked. Like at that point it was up to the producer or arranger wanting a special member or something. But there was always an A band, I'll put it that way. The A bands in New York for a long time was Richard Tee, Steve Gadd on drums, Ralph McDonald percussion, I mean Hugh McCracken on guitar, Eric Gale on guitar. Those were the A guys. Same thing here in L.A.

MR: Well a little trade secret for some reason I was thinking did you have a special technique to record acoustic basses, which always seems to be one of the harder things to do in the recording world?

HC: Yes they are. And I'll tell you one of the reasons is the fact that the basses sounded so different. Guys would say, "I don't know what's wrong." That bass. Go out there and listen to the bass. Put your ear up there and you could tell if the bass sound is a problem. Sometimes it's the guy playing a beautiful bass but he doesn't play it well. Some guys can walk in with a cheap bass and he sounds like he's magnificent. So it's usually not only the player but also the instrument that you're dealing with.

MR: Did you have a microphone in front of it?

HC: Listen you can microphone a bass, a guy playing an acoustic bass out in a room, an acoustic bass now, not the real bass, not the amplified bass. You can mic him three different ways. You can put a small drop like behind the bridge and put a small microphone there and you get really a good hand signal. You can really feel the hand on the strings. Sometimes just putting a microphone out there is fine. Sometimes putting a microphone in the [inaudible] is better than putting it overhead you know what I mean? It depends on the bass player and the instrument. I've had great — bass players are good — I've had a good experience — bass players, you could be a great bass player but he has a bad instrument. But he loves it. You've got a problem. Why doesn't it sound — it doesn't sound like last week when he did it on the date because it was another studio, that engineer was futzing with the bass and you know.

MR: I see. What are the most memorable artists that you've — I know it's like hundreds and hundreds of people that you've recorded, what stands out for you as one of the most enjoyable experiences?

HC: The enjoyable experience is when the artists really come in knowing what they want to do. Like I worked with Peggy Lee — always on time, always ready. Always she had the tune down. You know everything, no problems, we just did it. And there's those artists

they never went to the meetings with the artist and the producer — I mean the artist and the engineer or the artist and the band. If the artist doesn't go with those meetings he's losing something. You want the artist to be there with the producer or if the artist is the producer to work with the arranger. You don't want them doing that stuff on the date. That kills you. Now there are some producers who like to work that way. Like they want the creativity to be instant. You know like it happened in the studio. Some come in very prepared with an arranger or whatever and work very well. Some come in with nothing and they work it out in the studio. Depends on the artist. I've worked on both. I've worked when an artist comes in and they want it to be a single and they're really working on it and a guy comes in and he's never seen the tune he's working on it five or six hours. That's painful.

MR: The first time I ever saw in the studio tape slicing and splicing I was amazed that it worked. I just didn't know such a thing was done the first time I saw it. So do you recall the first time you ever did that and were you nervous about it?

HC: You bet. But it didn't happen very often. If I was a second engineer working behind let's say John Krause at Capitol — I mean he would — in those days on a date, I'm talking about twenty years ago, the engineer could turn around and say, "Would you take the first half of the tune up through the first chorus and cut it to the next take of the same chorus." You know and that happens on a date, when there's twenty guys in the room talking. That's when you can get in trouble, I mean as a second engineer. I as an engineer would get into a situation like that sometimes because the producers would like, "I'd like to hear the first chorus I loved in the tune, the bridge I loved that, but could you give me the second chorus of take twelve." Then you've got to juggle and whizzle around. And hopefully you can make all the cuts.

MR: Am I correct that you would manipulate the tape over the heads so that you would hear —

HC: Absolu— yes. No, I'll tell you what, you want pressure? You're working on a — at Capitol, I'm working on a Peggy Lee date or something. And as a second engineer you're running the machines. And then the producer says, "But could we keep the first chorus on that take and go to take twelve" or whatever, "and put that second chorus together." And usually it's the second engineer who is running the machines that does the editing if he's good. And I mean if you're working at Capitol or Columbia they expect those second engineers to be able to do that and inevitably — let's say you're working on a Sinatra date, which I did many times, and he'd say, "Take the first chorus from this take and put that together." And they come in the control room and they're all talking. And you're trying to make an edit. And I would say "Shut the F up I can't hear what I'm doing." "Oh okay." "Take it outside I can't hear what I'm doing." I mean you make an edit and if you

make a dumb edit and you screw it up you look like a fool. Don't look like a fool, tell them to get the hell out of the room so you can hear what you are doing.

MR: That's even done with classical recordings, isn't it?

HC: Classical recordings are generally, if you make edits in a classical recording I mean those cuts are made by a producer and the artist, because it's usually an orchestra and I've done those big classical orchestras when you get an artist you know of the caliber, they want to be there when you're editing and stuff like that. And sometimes you're better off editing yourself with a producer. Sometimes if you're editing with the producer and an artist the artist can get really crazy about I want this take and I want those four bars and it's into one of those things. We used to call them suicide missions because you knew that certain artists were always into editing. Let's take one and two and we'll put them together.

MR: Yeah once they see that that stuff is possible then they start thinking, oh okay, now I know what I can do.

HC: Exactly. See if we can have a better take on take three. "I'd like to take that second chorus, it's really good." "Okay." And then they start talking to somebody and the second engineer is trying to make the edits. Until we had — you know what these Editall 12-blocks are now, you know, when every machine has a block where you can add it — you can put it in this thing and you find out where you are and you make a nice even cut. Years ago we used to use scissors. And you know you've got chorus one and chorus two, "Oh let's get chorus two from track" whatever. So you have to put them together. In those days, because they had Editall blocks, now every machine's got a block on it. They're called Editall blocks so you get straight lines. In the old days you had, the engineers had a scissor — I can't describe — but we would fly under it with your hand, like you'd flip it out and there would be the blades and you'd make the cut, flip the scissor back in again and make the cut and put it together.

MR: Did you cut at an angle?

HC: Always at an angle.

MR: And what is the reason for that?

HC: So that it runs smoothly across the heads.

MR: I see.

HC: You know what I mean? First of all you shouldn't ever have a problem if you make a cut and put it together and if you're a good engineer and a good editor you're going to make it once and it's not going to be — if you're not good and you missed the downbeat and some second guy doesn't know what he's doing and he lost the tape because he put the — you know if you're the engineer that's running the date you've got to make sure that while everybody's talking, with one ear on what the second guy's doing to make that cut. And if you're not sure of him being able to make the cut I have done many times,

because I know that the second engineer is a new guy, he's a little nervous about making a cut on a date, I would never say a word. I'd just go and make the cut myself. I don't want to put that guy under any kind of pressure. And luckily I worked with a lot of great engineers when I was coming up and that's the way they operated, that's the way they worked. Until they got comfortable with you, or I got comfortable with the second to make him make the edit, you know. But if I wasn't sure about the guy making the edit I don't want him to take the wrong take you know. Like you say put — I'm keeping the first chorus from the this take and the second chorus from take 12. You'd better make sure that he knows where he's going and the whole control room is talking at the same time. You know? And you've got to keep them talking and pay attention, but the other ear is listening to where the second guy is going.

MR: I'm going to test your memory here. Did you, when you worked with the Monkees did you record the tune "Daydream Believer?"

HC: Yeah.

MR: There's a moment near the end of that song where this flugelhorn comes in with this beautiful countermelody [scats]. Do you remember that?

HC: No. It's amazing with those kind of things, I know I understand that but actually I did that six months ago. You know? I don't remember what I did six months ago.

MR: Yeah, I know. It's just this — I've always loved that moment and I'm curious which studio cat played that.

HC: I'll tell you the things — I got into a thing a couple of times with Tom Scott but what we actually did was it was a transition from one tune to another tune where you could just do it with two pots. But there were a couple of times where Tom wanted to keep the thing going a little longer so you had the cut that you normally would make, this is not going to work. We would do these really surgical things. You'd take, instead of Editall block, which is really six inches, you take two pieces of masking tape and put them down and put the tape between them and you can make a long splice and you've got a six inch edit. You've made a transition if you could do it with two pots it's one thing to another mix. But if you're trying to tape that mix together I've done that many times, and you're cross-fading between two pieces. You'd be better right when you're cutting that kind of stuff.

MR: Yeah he told me that you would do mixes where you had sixteen faders and he had sixteen and I can almost picture how that, "No, no, not yet, don't push that up yet."

HC: It happens occasionally. But if you're a good editor nobody's ever going to bother you with that stuff.

MR: Yes.

HC: I mean I was really good because I worked with a lot of great guys. My career was — when I went to work at Capitol I had worked in the business for a while, you had to start

from the very — at Capitol when you started you started in the cutting rooms where they physically cut albums and records. So you got to hear what all these engineers were doing, which was a good training ground. By the time you got — they always started in the cutting rooms and then if you were really good okay now you can work down in the studios as a second. You know? And then from working as a second you get a build-up of relationships of producers, artists and the next thing a producer will say, "Gee, let me use Hank on this and I think Hank will be a good engineer on this." And then that's how you get a start. And then the producer hangs onto you and you know.

MR: Was it an odd feeling or did you ever have the circumstance where you spent a great deal of time on a recording and it was done and then only to be ruined or changed in the mastering process?

HC: That's happened a few times. Generally — I don't know how to put this — sometimes the guy in the cutting room is hearing something that you didn't hear. You know? And he'll ask you, "Gee you guys made a cut here but it doesn't sound right." No that's wrong too, I mean at that point if the guy says that you get nervous. But sometimes the guys in the cutting room will catch something and say hey, this doesn't sound right, what did you do. And you know I don't know how that worked because I never made any major mistakes, knock on wood thank God.

MR: Yeah.

HC: The worst part of a job in a big studio for a second engineer was to be in the middle of a date, you're doing — Billy May's out there with a big band, you've got a hot producer, you've got a hot engineer, and they turn around and say, "I like the first chorus of track 12 and I put it together with the track of 18" or whatever. They're all starting to talk and you're trying to find what take it is. You know? That's when you get into — it gets crazy. And I always talk like a second engineer because I've been it myself. I would write down the start of the take by numbers, I could see that on the machine. You know? And then I knew that that's where the start was, 82 or whatever. And, "Let's get to the third take," I knew where that was I'd just reel the tape up, instead of trying to hunt for where it started. I wrote down the number. I knew that it started at 82, I'd go to 82 and there's the start of it. I always used to write them on the box.

MR: Before we wrap up here, I wanted to ask you about two individuals. Duke Ellington. Did you work with Ellington?

HC: No.

MR: Okay. How about Phil Spector?

HC: No, I never worked with Phil Spector thank God.

MR: Do you regret that?

HC: No, not at all. I mean I worked with some great producers, I mean going back to Dot Records, Tom Mack who did Harry James and a lot of big bands, Woody Herman and I got really tight with some of those producers at Dot and it was really great to do those. I worked with Tom Mack, we worked with somebody in the big bands, he was in Glenn Miller's original band. He was a producer at Dot Records. And you know he was just great to work with. They were great musicians so it was really great to work with him. Guys like that. The guys that you didn't want to work with were those guys, the artist would say, "I want to make a cut." If a guy wanted to make a cut in a certain place and you knew it was wrong and you tried to tell them it was wrong and they don't want to be embarrassed by the fact that they're talking to you and they've got you in the wrong place. You've got to gently, you know I've done a couple of times. They'll say, "Cut it right there" and you know you can't cut it there because the brass section is playing. You don't say anything, just move the tape up, you know, make the cut and let it go. Sometimes a producer — we used to call them [deliberately inaudible].

MR: You used to call them what?

HC: Flying F cuts.

MR: Okay.

HC: "Cut it there." "Cut it where? Where's the downbeat, where do you want me to cut it?" And if you cut it in the wrong place, you're not a mind reader.

MR: What is your opinion, you're driving down the street these days, the music that you hear coming out of some cars is very different from what you would have heard coming out of cars in the 1960s.

HC: You bet. I think that we worked a lot better in the 60s. I mean we were, you know, our equipment has gotten better since the 60s but I don't think that, you know music doesn't change. Music is music. And whether you do a date with Duke Ellington in 1960 or you do a date with Duke Ellington now, the music is still there. You've just got to make it better. I mean I was a second engineer on a lot of Duke Ellington dates and boy they flew. You know you had to be real quick. You could turn around and say, "Give me that second chorus" and you're trying to find where the second chorus was, and they're all talking and drinking coffee.

MR: What possessed you to try to get the members of the Monkees to play their own instruments?

HC: I didn't really have much to do with that. Let's see —

MR: Chip Douglas?

HC: Well Chip came in later. I had already done two albums, but that was all right. When Chip came in they all wanted to do their own stuff and their own playing, so it was a little strange. A lot of them were not players before they began. For example in the drums

Mickey didn't, he never played drums before. But they wanted to make him the drummer. So Columbia sends the drums over to his house and where the guys dropped the drums is where he learned to play. So the snare was on the wrong side and the toms were on the wrong side. But that's the way they set it up and it was three or four weeks every day, every night, he played those drums. When he came to the studio I set up the drums the way I normally would. And he looked at them and he said, "No, I don't know what to do with this." Because for weeks now he's been playing all by himself at his house bashing away and the snare wasn't in the right place for him in the studio, it was on the wrong side. It should have been on the right side, it's on the left side. That kind of thing. And I had to adjust that. Does that make sense?

MR: It does. It's like learning a guitar left handed or backwards.

HC: Right. Exactly. Exactly. And a lot of those things they didn't play very well.

MR: Well you've seen it all, that's for sure.

HC: Boy, and more. I've seen — I thought I saw it all and then something would — somebody would come in with something I never even heard of before. I remember everybody got into this Japanese thing and suddenly I had a date and they would bring in a koto, you know the Japanese string instrument.

MR: A koto. Yes.

HC: You know it's a big guitar kind of thing. The strings are on the top. And I just looked at it and how am I going to mic this thing? And I put mics, two microphones on top and it just didn't sound right. I couldn't get it to where I wanted it. And I said, "Let's put a microphone" because you know it sits on a stand. "Put a microphone underneath and let's see what it sounds like. I put a microphone underneath and all the strings sounded separately, like they were supposed to be. I had the mic on top it didn't sound right. It sounded cluttered. I mean you just have to experiment sometimes because you know that kind of a guitar sitting up on a stand you could put a microphone underneath it and that's what I did and it cleaned up the sound. So you know, sometimes you can't take what the artist is telling you. "Here mic it here." So you mic it there and God it sounds awful.

MR: Okay last question, if you put in a ten hour day in the studio, when you got out did you want to hear silence?

HC: You mean when I went home?

MR: When you got home. Did you just like oh my ears, I've got to hear nothing?

HC: No I would clear myself out, if I'm doing like a rock & roll date, and I used to live in Woodland Hills, that was a long way from the studio. I would listen to jazz and stuff. I never blocked out one thing or the other. If I was doing jazz I was doing jazz. If I was doing rock & roll —

MR: All right. Well I want to thank you for your time today. This was very informative and congratulations on your career.

HC: Thank you. It's been fun.

MR: Good. You ever get like phantom checks in the mail from anything you recorded?

HC: Random checks in the mail! I wish. Oh I've gotten a couple of good reviews but I've always wished, "The check's in the mail." But I mean if I produced something I would get checks in the mail, but you know it depends on the producers you're working with. If you work with a guy like Lou Adler there's a lot more to it than just money. He's a producer and he's producing good records and that means a lot.

MR: All right. Well I'll see if I can send a random check your way.

HC: Okay. It'll go somewhere I'm sure.

MR: All right. Thanks a lot, Hank.

HC: If I can do any more for you, please call.

MR: All right.

HC: Thank you.

MR: You're very welcome. And yeah I wish I could have been a fly on the wall on some of those dates you did.

HC: Well if you come up with something let me know. I mean we did so many things that were different. Like I told you my big thing with Carole King, I always wanted them to sit all around together so they were all looking at each other, the band that it, which usually was a drums and a couple of guitars and Carole playing piano. I put them right close and they all worked together.

MR: All right.